



Like mom like son

and incorporated them into my vocabulary. I even recognised letters. Till date, people are surprised when they come to know that I can read and write Kannada!" she quips.

While engineers were not expected to go to the shop floor all the time, Chitra established a camaraderie and gained the respect of the technicians who would answer all her inquiries about the workflow and willingly accept her suggestions.

Sailing through love and loss

Throughout her journey at ITI, Chitra donned multiple roles: a senior manager, a daughter, a wife, and a mother. "It was an arranged marriage. While I was busy working, my sister and my father sifted through prospective grooms for me. Even today, whenever there is a big festival or function, my sister, now a doctor, has a brand new saree ready for me because she knows I would not even bother thinking about it," laughs Chitra. This is the beauty of having a lovely sibling!

The following years saw Chitra undergo various transitions in her personal and professional life. While donning the hat of a wife in 1990, Chitra also transitioned to the Madras VLSI Design Centre of ITI.

She needed to move to Chennai to be with her extremely supportive husband Hariharan, who was then a dairy manager of the Aavin milk cooperative in Tamil Nadu, and father-in-law Sankaralingam. The following year, Chitra, who was soon to become a mother, lost her father. "We named our son, Rajagopal, after my father," she says.

With the support of her father-in-law and husband, Chitra did not dwell on the loss and quickly took on her duties as a mother while also being a part of the research and design team at ITI. "My father-in-law never let me feel the absence of my father. He encouraged me to go ahead and aim higher. When I moved to the USA to join RealChip Communications, he took on the role of a second mother for my son, and never once let anything come in the way of my career aspirations," she recalls.

"We had a 30-minute calling card for international calls in those days. There were times when the phone call just got cut while my son was in the middle of narrating an exciting

anecdote from school. Those were the moments when the mother's guilt seeped in, but I consoled myself knowing that my child was safe and loved," she reminisces.

In the epic battle of *Mahabharata*, Hindu deity Krishna, drove Arjuna's chariot throughout the battle, while the latter fought the mighty battle. A staunch devotee of the Hindu deity Krishna, Chitra acknowledges her strength and determination to Krishna, her chariot-er, who charted her into a lifelong adventure on wheels—an adventure that started in Coimbatore on the modified-men's cycle.

Wheels instead of feet

In 2001, Chitra saw an opportunity at Intel Microelectronics, a startup within Intel that wanted to set up a hardware design centre in Bengaluru. Little did she know that life would take her places and bring her back to Intel as the Head of Strategy for the HPG Group, in another 15 years. Propelled by her pragmatism and the opportunity to come back home, Chitra took on a new challenge and entered her era of building startups. As usual, every decision that Chitra had ever taken till then came with tough choices. This, too, did.

While the distance between oceans narrowed to two states, Chitra had to choose to continue to shuttle between Chennai and Bengaluru. She spent her weekdays in Bengaluru and took the first transport back to Chennai on the weekends. "To date, my friends and family say that you have wheels instead of feet!" she jokes.

Raising a child while building a startup from scratch was no mean feat. While her family supported her dreams, Chitra recalls a Wednesday morning phone call from her son's school in Chennai. "I just picked up my purse and rushed to his school



Proud mom and daughters